CAB Meetings • Change Requests (CR)
Hot Freeze vs Cold Freeze (Real IT Work)

Live session handout • 25 Feb 2026

Learning outcomes

- What CAB is and why organisations use it for production change control.
- Change Request (CR) with impact, risk, testing, and rollback details.
- Differentiate Hot Freeze vs Cold Freeze and when each applies.
- End-to-end change workflow from request to post-implementation review (PIR).
- Identify common reasons changes are rejected and how to avoid them.

Session flow

1. What is CAB and what happens in a CAB meeting
2. How to write a Change Request (CR)
3. CAB decision-making using a checklist (Approve / Reject / Need more info)
4. Hot Freeze vs Cold Freeze (rules and exceptions)
5. Practice activity with a sample CR

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Key terms (quick meanings)

Term	Meaning (in real work)
CAB (Change Advisory Board)	A group/process that reviews risky production changes to reduce outages and business impact.
Change Request (CR)	A formal record that explains a production change (what, why, impact, risk, testing, rollback).
Change Window	Approved time slot when the change will be done (often off-peak).
Impact	Who/what could be affected if the change fails (users, services, revenue, SLA).
Risk	Chance of failure and how serious it would

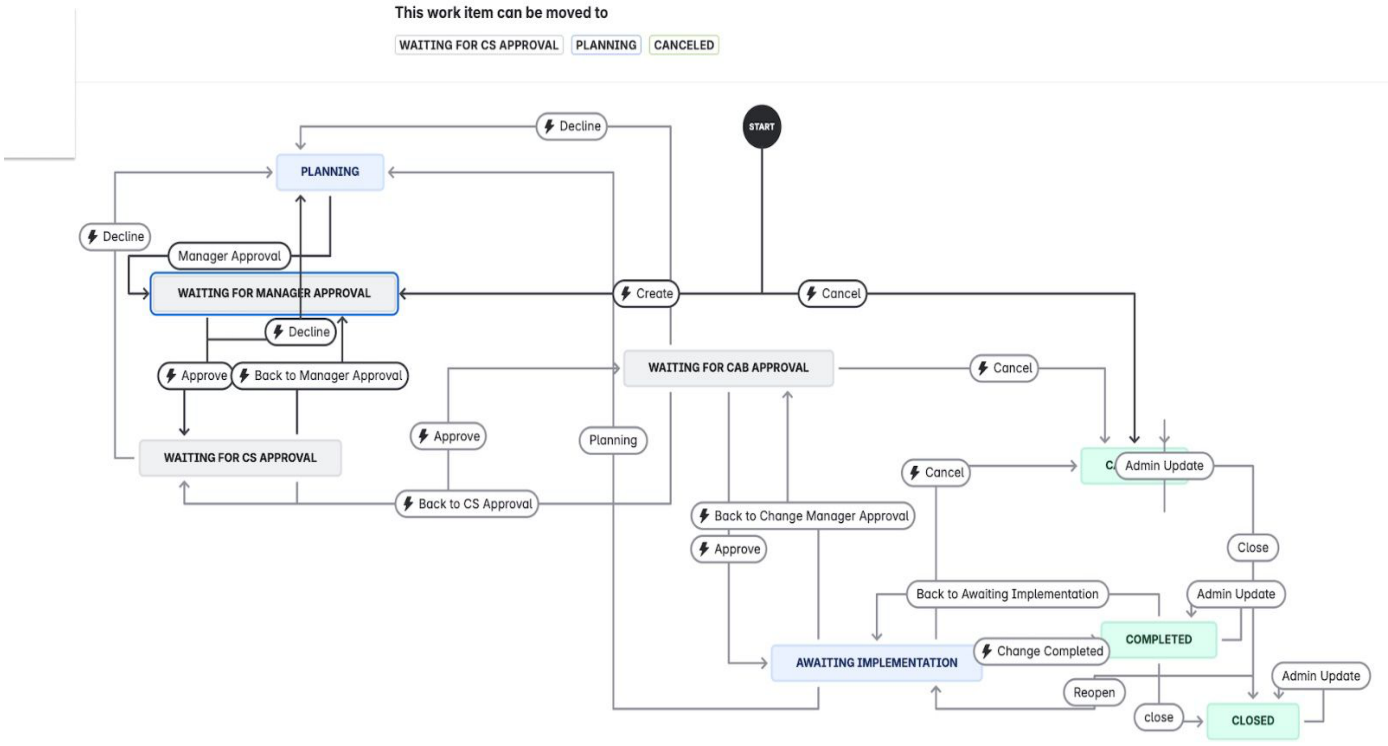
	be. Includes how you reduce the risk.
Testing evidence	Proof the change was tested (e.g., staging/UAT/smoke tests) and results.
Rollback/Backout	Steps to safely revert the change if something breaks.
PIR (Post-Implementation Review)	Short review after the change: what happened, what went well, what to improve.

End-to-end change control workflow (simple)

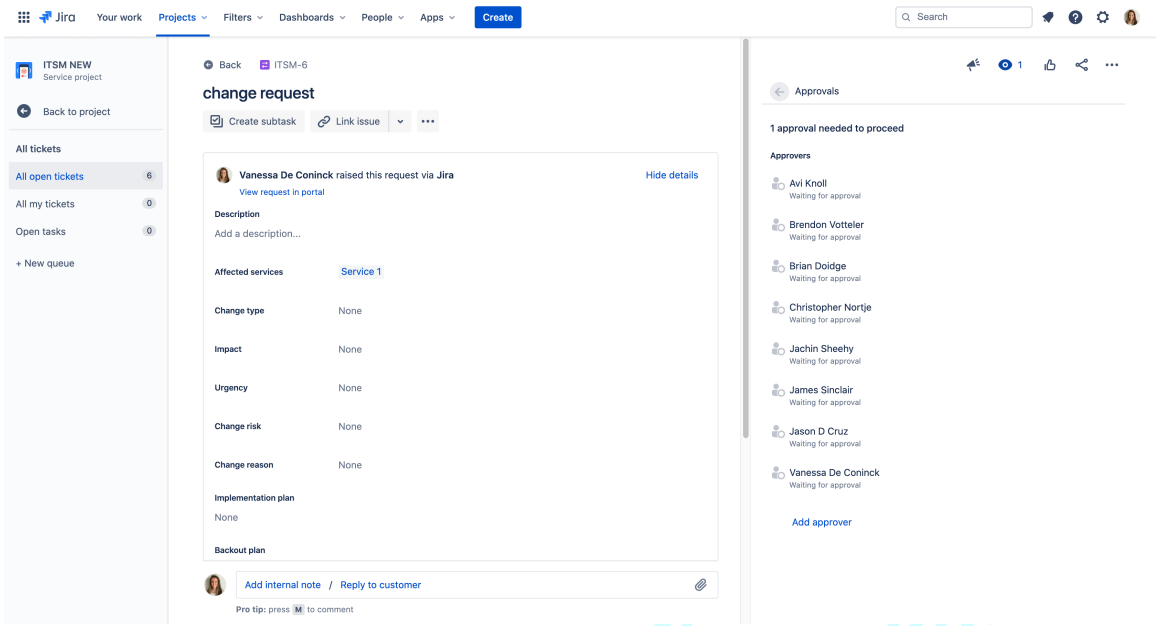
6. Create CR (describe the change and business reason).
7. Assess impact and dependencies (what services/teams/users are affected).
8. Assess risk and mitigations (what can go wrong and how you reduce it).
9. Add testing evidence (what you tested and the results).
10. Write rollback plan (how to revert and how long it will take).
11. CAB review (questions asked + decision made).
12. Implement in change window (follow steps/runbook).
13. Validate and monitor (checks, logs, metrics, alerts).
14. Close CR and complete PIR if required (record outcome and lessons learned).

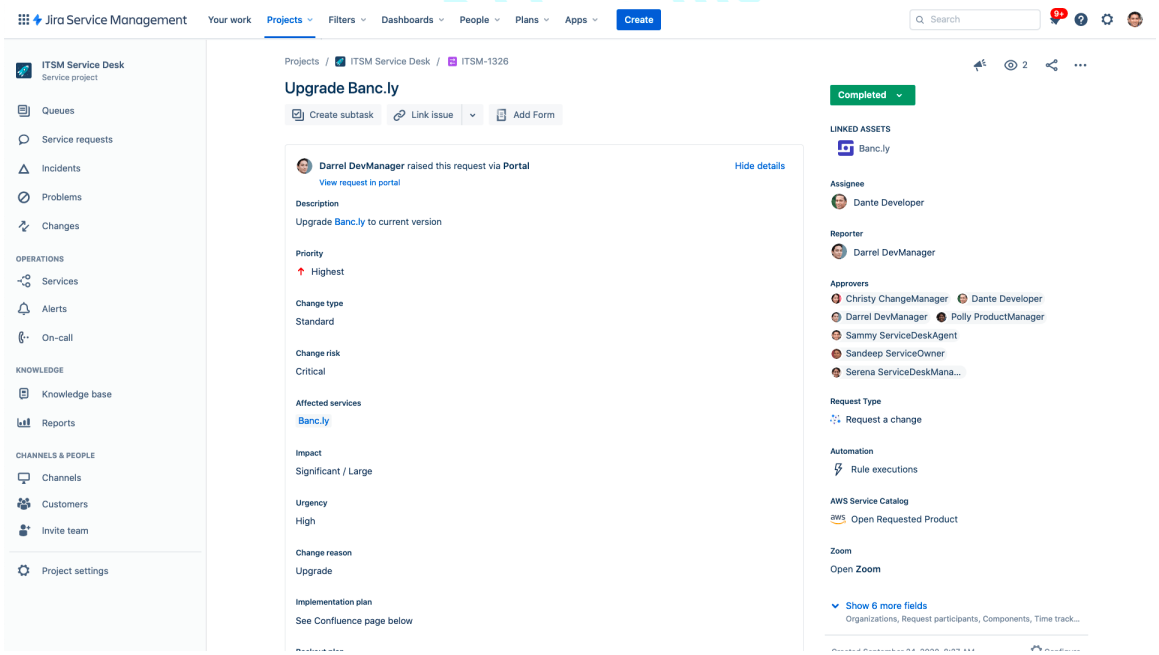
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Change Workflow

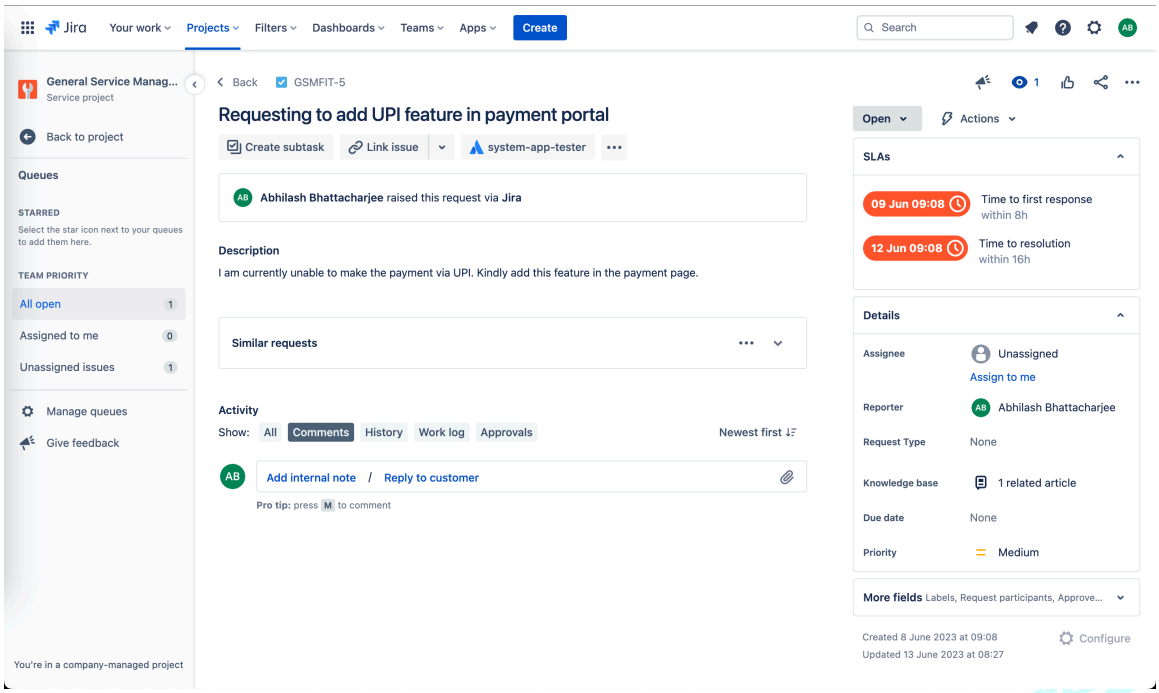


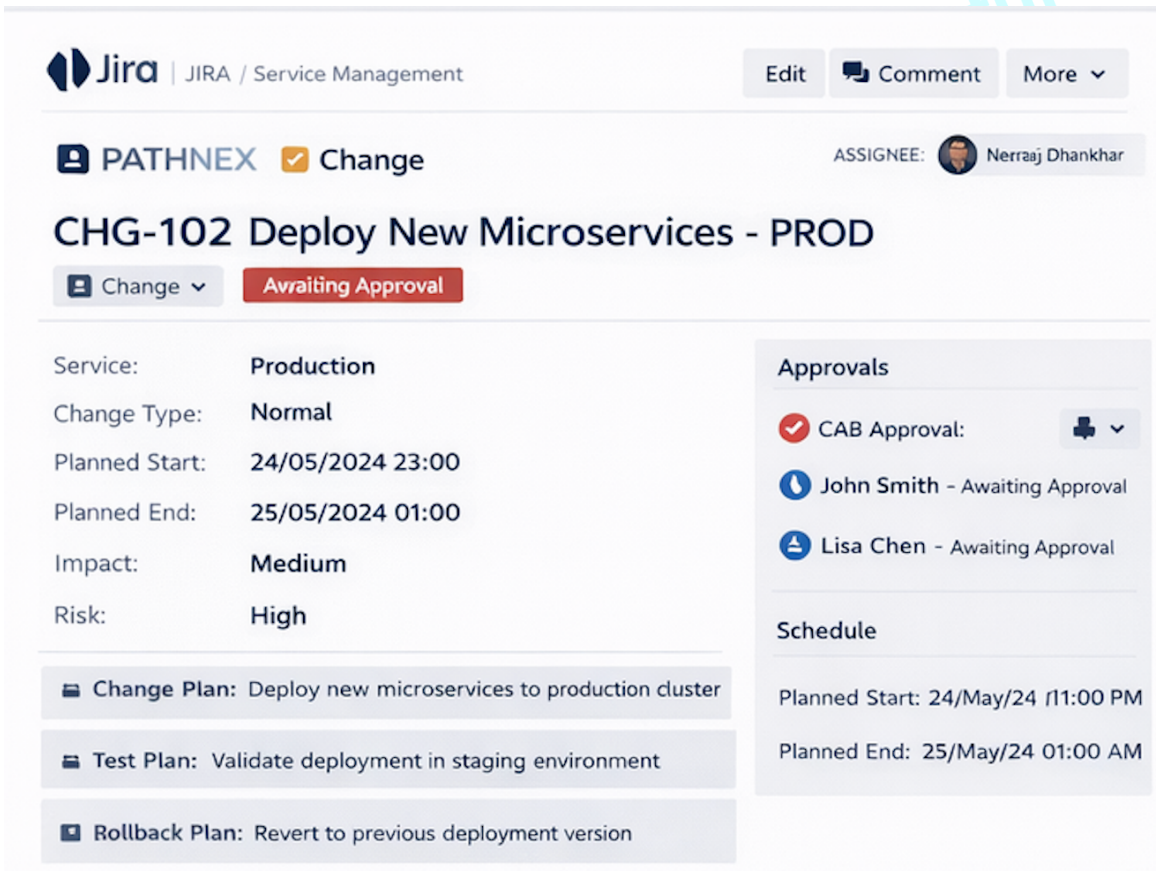
Change Request (CR) template



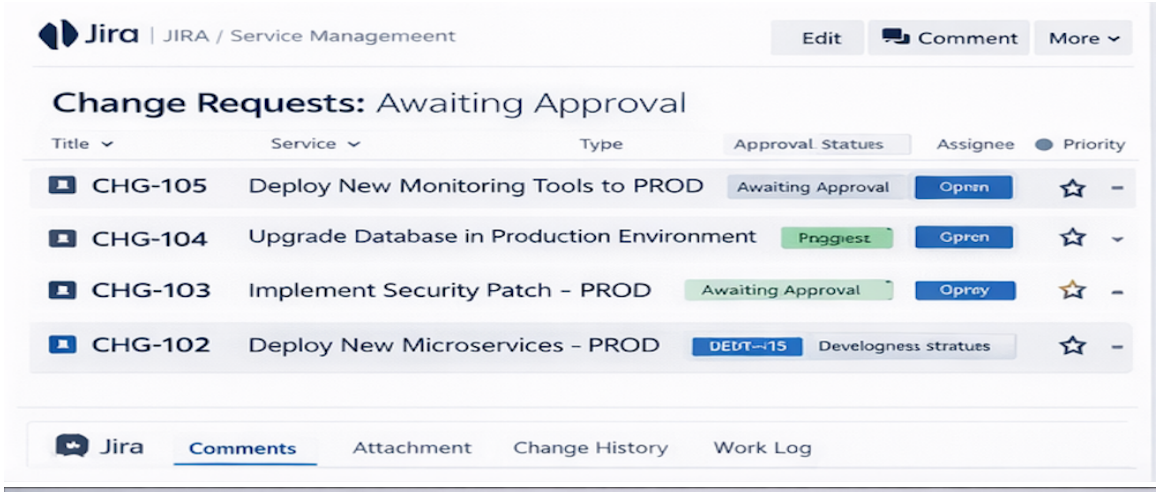


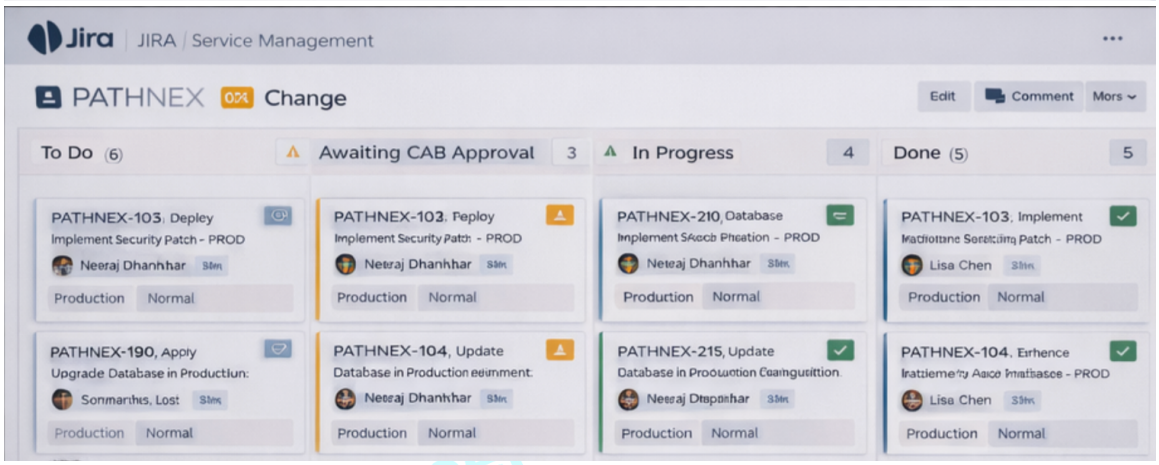
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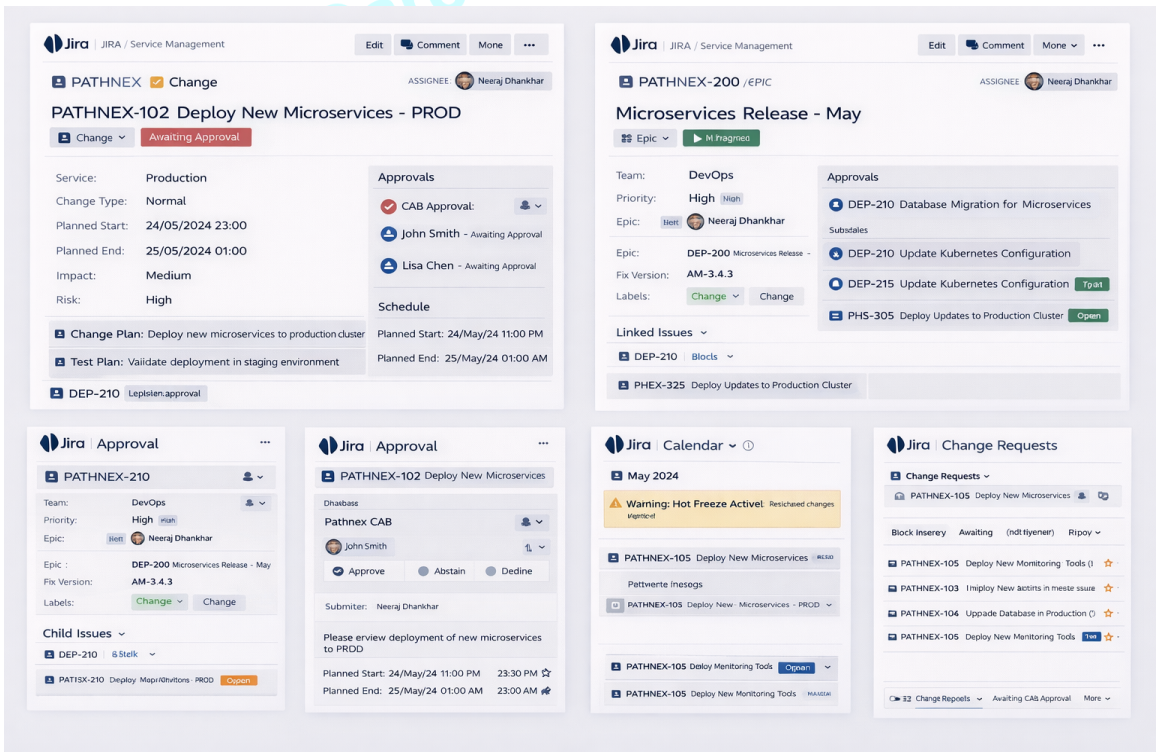




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CR title: _____

System/service: _____

Change type: ☐ Standard ☐ Normal ☐ Emergency

1) What is changing (1–2 lines):

_____

_____

2) Why are we doing this (business reason):

_____

3) Impact (users/services/downtime/dependencies):

_____

_____

4) Risk level: ☐ Low ☐ Medium ☐ High Why? _____

5) Testing evidence (where + what results):

_____

_____

6) Rollback plan (how to revert + time):

_____

_____

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7) Implementation steps (high level):

_____

_____

8) Monitoring/validation after release:

_____

9) Communication (who needs to know):

_____

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CAB checklist (use this to decide)

- Is the CR clear (what, where, why)?
- Is impact written (downtime, affected users, dependencies)?
- Is risk assessed and mitigations included?
- Is testing evidence included (not just 'tested')?
- Is there a realistic rollback plan with time estimate?
- Is the change scheduled in the right window? Any conflict with freezes?
- Are the right people available (executor + on-call) and communications planned?

Decision: ☐ APPROVE ☐ REJECT ☐ NEED MORE INFO

Reason (1–2 lines): _____

Hot Freeze vs Cold Freeze (quick comparison)

Aspect	Hot Freeze	Cold Freeze
Why it starts	Active incident or instability	Planned business/critical period
Duration	Short (hours to days)	Longer (days to weeks)
What is allowed	Emergency fixes only	Critical fixes only (exceptions possible)
Approval path	Fast-track / emergency approval	Exception approval + strong justification
Goal	Stability first	Protect business operations

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